Computers

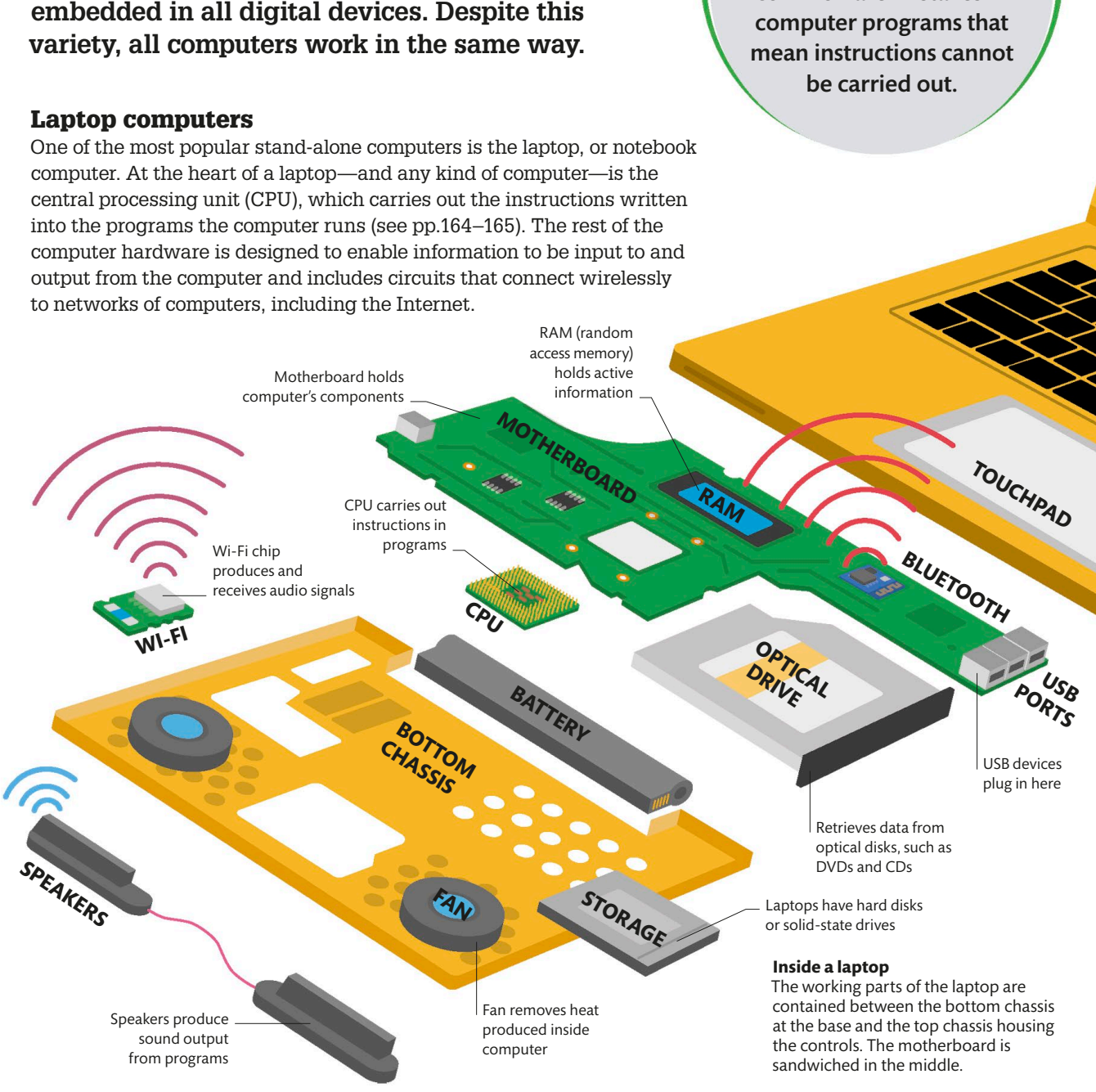
Computers come in many shapes and sizes, including laptops, desktops, tablets, and smartphones. There are also computers embedded in all digital devices. Despite this variety, all computers work in the same way.

WHY DO COMPUTERS CRASH?

A computer can crash (freeze) for many reasons, but most common are mistakes in computer programs that mean instructions cannot be carried out.

Laptop computers

One of the most popular stand-alone computers is the laptop, or notebook computer. At the heart of a laptop—and any kind of computer—is the central processing unit (CPU), which carries out the instructions written into the programs the computer runs (see pp.164–165). The rest of the computer hardware is designed to enable information to be input to and output from the computer and includes circuits that connect wirelessly to networks of computers, including the Internet.



Inside a laptop
The working parts of the laptop are contained between the bottom chassis at the base and the top chassis housing the controls. The motherboard is sandwiched in the middle.